



Market UNBOUND

The challenge for India lies in being connected—the essential precondition for building a competitive and innovative economy

— By **SUNIL BHARTI MITTAL**

When I think about India's emerging economic clout on the world scene, I am reminded of Victor Hugo's famous quote: "No power on Earth can stop an idea whose time has come". This was made more famous, although in a different context, here in India by one of Dr Manmohan Singh's Budget speeches in the 1990s. Today, many global observers perceive a sense of inevitability about India's rising economic status alongside China in

the long run. I have no hesitation to weighing in with this rapidly growing group.

However, I also believe that "nothing happens until you make it happen". Hence, clear advantages notwithstanding, Indians have to make it happen. Every stakeholder—from political leaders, bureaucrats and entrepreneurs to farmers and artisans in the countryside—needs to play out his designated role to usher in the big transformation.

For India, the big advantage lies in being a young nation. More than half of India's population today is below 25 years and, more importantly, about 40 per cent is below the age of 18. If the future ageing pattern is compared to the rest of the world, it becomes evident that our

youthfulness is here to stay for a long time.

A sustainable young population clearly points to two things; a longstanding productive working population and a huge domestic consumer market, which is predicted to become the fifth largest consumer market in the world by 2025, in a study by McKinsey.

A caveat here though is that the largest young population on the face of earth cannot become an asset purely by its numerical superiority. Nobody realises this better than us, who have had a large population, but did not look at it as an asset. The large population needs continuous nurture to make it the potent force that people have been so passionately talking about of late. Sustained investments in soft in-

● India forms 12 per cent of the world-wide business jets market. The demand for private or business jets in India is expected to grow at 50 per cent annually over the next few years.